# Alert Contents:

**Title: Suspicious svchost Outbound Connection Observed**

**Time: 2022-04-04 02:48:19 UTC**

**Hostname: DESKTOP-NTN82M**

**User: Sally**

**Process: C:\Windows\svchost[.]exe**

**Outbound Connection: 43[.]128[.]141[.]86:6985**

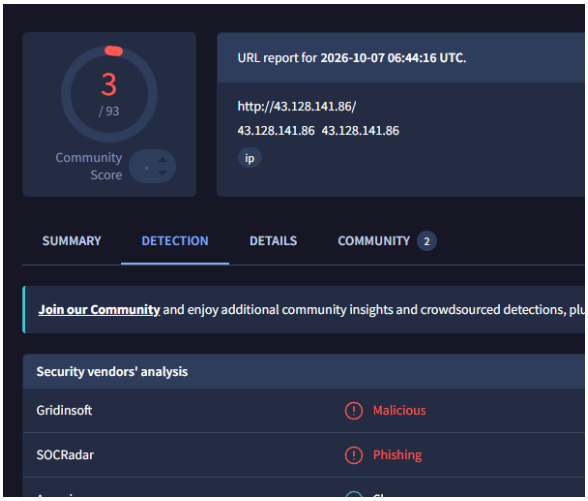
**File Hash: c3095cea4f4901ea9a22e63aa45b9aa54969f7ecb210eee9af551d23eafb6f1a**

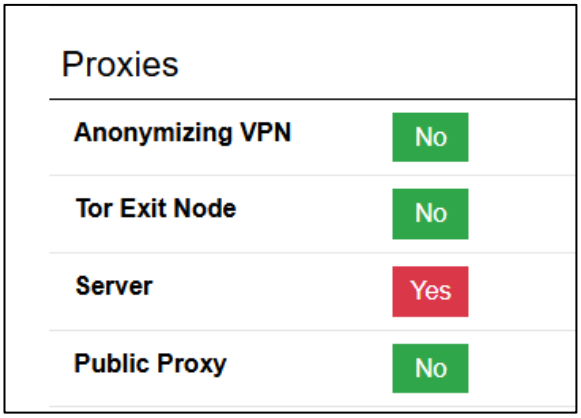
# Investigation

**Summary:**

At 2022-04-04 02:48:19 UTC, an outbound connection to a suspicious IP address has been detected on DESKTOP-NTN82M under Sally's account. The process that caused this is masquerading as svchost.exe in the Windows folder instead of the normal system32 location. The file hash has a reputation of installing Cobalt Strike, a penetration testing software often used in cyber-attacks, where it is leveraged to beacon out to the same IP Address detected by the alert, a possible C2 server.

**IOC IP:** 43[.]128[.]141[.]86



| Operator | |
|---|---|
| **Hostname** | n/a |
| **ASN** | 132203 |
| **ISP Name** | Shenzhen Tencent Computer Systems Company Limited |
| **Organization Name** | Tencent Cloud Computing |
| **Connection type** | n/a |

3 vendors flagged the IP address as malicious, being used in previous phishing attacks on VirusTotal. Scamalytics reports the IP as a server possibly created using Tencent Cloud Computing cloud services.

**SHA256 Hash:** c3095cea4f4901ea9a22e63aa45b9aa54969f7ecb210eee9af551d23eafb6f1a

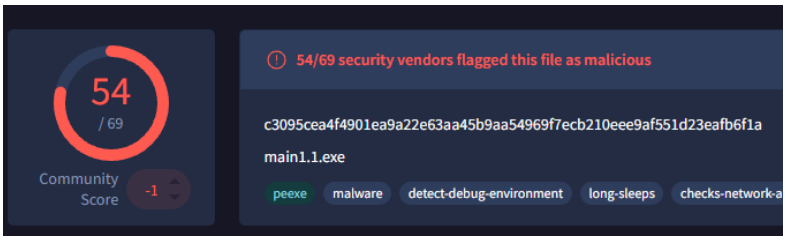
**Additional Suspicious File:**

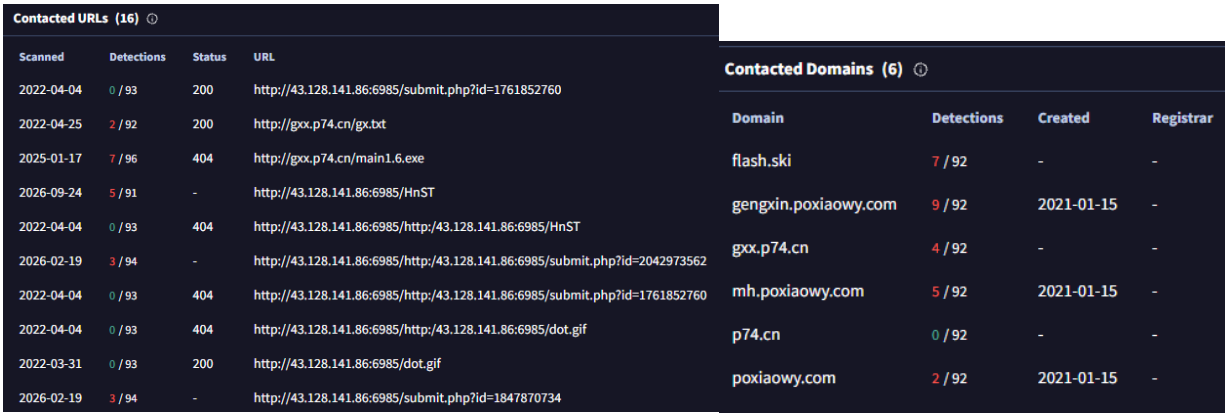
windowsUpdate[.]exe, MD5 Hash: 05D764F508231105BB212107C782DB80

**IOC Domains:** flash[.]ski, poxiaowy[.]com, p74[.]cn

**IOC Process:** C:\Windows\svchost[.]exe

The file hash has been flagged by high amount of security vendors on VirusTotal where it has also been reported as being used to download Cobalt Strike, a commercial penetration testing software that is often leveraged to beacon out to a C2 server. The same out-bound IP address detected in our environment is listed in several known Contacted URLs as well. This file is also known to use Masquerading as a technique. In our environment, it poses as svchost.exe from the Windows folder when the legitimate svchost.exe exists in the System32 folder. Joe Sandbox detected Cobalt Strike and the malware creates windowsUpdate[.]exe in the system32 folder when no such file exists in the folder normally. The contacted domains listed in VirusTotal have been flagged as malicious, but no other recent information can be found on them as they are currently unreachable.



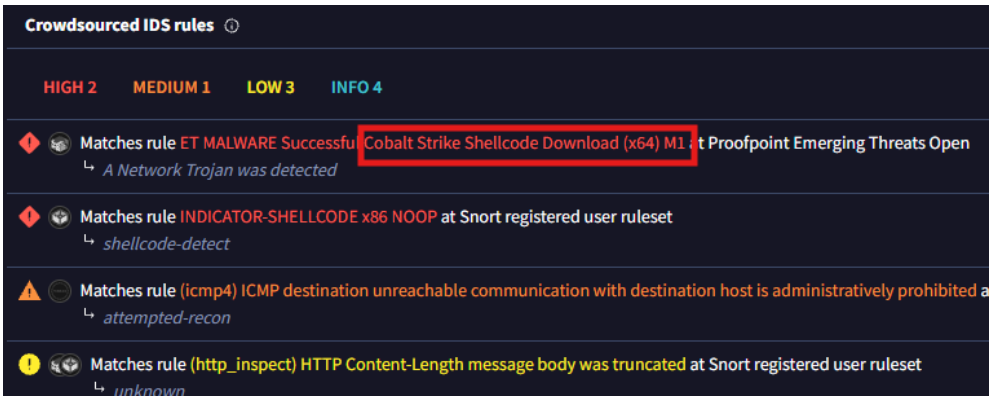


**Contacted URLs (16)**

| Scanned | Detections | Status | URL |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2022-04-04 | 0 / 93 | 200 | http://43.128.141.86:6985/submit.php?id=1761852760 |
| 2022-04-25 | 2 / 92 | 200 | http://gxx.p74.cn/gx.txt |
| 2025-01-17 | 7 / 96 | 404 | http://gxx.p74.cn/main1.6.exe |
| 2026-09-24 | 5 / 91 | - | http://43.128.141.86:6985/HnST |
| 2022-04-04 | 0 / 93 | 404 | http://43.128.141.86:6985/http:/43.128.141.86:6985/HnST |
| 2026-02-19 | 3 / 94 | - | http://43.128.141.86:6985/http:/43.128.141.86:6985/submit.php?id=2042973562 |
| 2022-04-04 | 0 / 93 | 404 | http://43.128.141.86:6985/http:/43.128.141.86:6985/submit.php?id=1761852760 |
| 2022-04-04 | 0 / 93 | 404 | http://43.128.141.86:6985/http:/43.128.141.86:6985/dot.gif |
| 2022-03-31 | 0 / 93 | 200 | http://43.128.141.86:6985/dot.gif |
| 2026-02-19 | 3 / 94 | - | http://43.128.141.86:6985/submit.php?id=1847870734 |

**Contacted Domains (6)**

| Domain | Detections | Created | Registrar |
|---|---|---|---|
| flash.ski | 7 / 92 | - | - |
| gengxin.poxiaowy.com | 9 / 92 | 2021-01-15 | - |
| gxx.p74.cn | 4 / 92 | - | - |
| mh.poxiaowy.com | 5 / 92 | 2021-01-15 | - |
| p74.cn | 0 / 92 | - | - |
| poxiaowy.com | 2 / 92 | 2021-01-15 | - |



**Crowdsourced IDS rules**

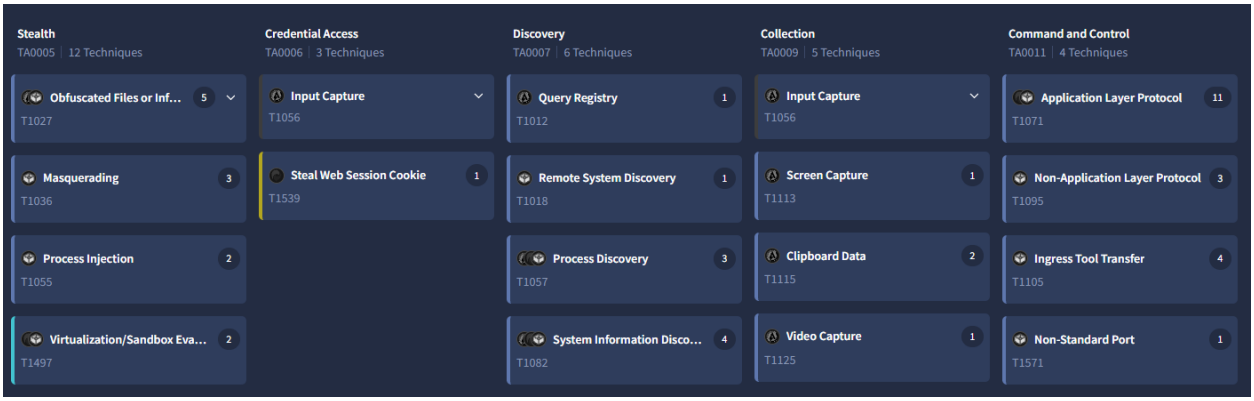
HIGH 2 MEDIUM 1 LOW 3 INFO 4

Matches rule ET MALWARE Successfu Cobalt Strike Shellcode Download (x64) M1 t Proofpoint Emerging Threats Open
↳ *A Network Trojan was detected*

Matches rule INDICATOR-SHELLCODE x86 NOOP at Snort registered user ruleset
↳ *shellcode-detect*

Matches rule (icmp4) ICMP destination unreachable communication with destination host is administratively prohibited a
↳ *attempted-recon*

Matches rule (http_inspect) HTTP Content-Length message body was truncated at Snort registered user ruleset
↳ *unknown*



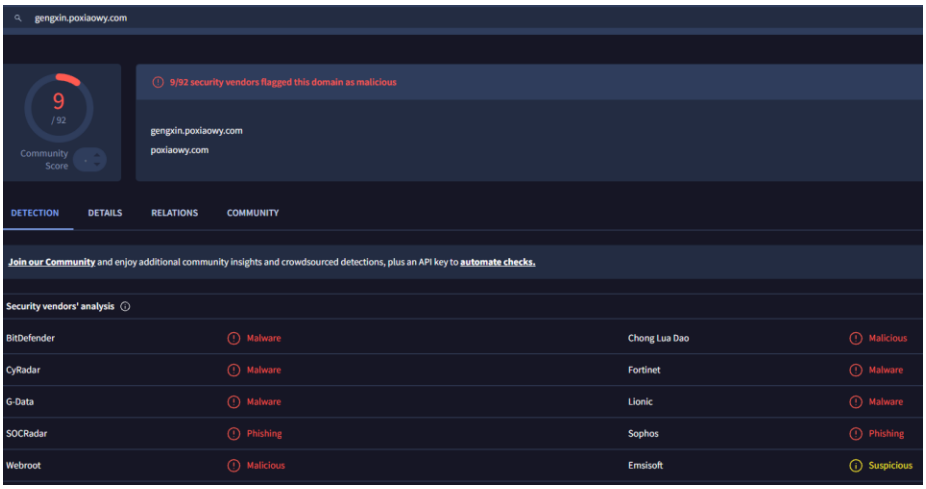
| Stealth<br>TA0005 \| 12 Techniques | Credential Access<br>TA0006 \| 3 Techniques | Discovery<br>TA0007 \| 6 Techniques | Collection<br>TA0009 \| 5 Techniques | Command and Control<br>TA0011 \| 4 Techniques |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Obfuscated Files or Inf... 5<br>T1027 | Input Capture<br>T1056 | Query Registry 1<br>T1012 | Input Capture<br>T1056 | Application Layer Protocol 11<br>T1071 |
| Masquerading 3<br>T1036 | Steal Web Session Cookie 1<br>T1539 | Remote System Discovery 1<br>T1018 | Screen Capture 1<br>T1113 | Non-Application Layer Protocol 3<br>T1095 |
| Process Injection 2<br>T1055 | | Process Discovery 3<br>T1057 | Clipboard Data 2<br>T1115 | Ingress Tool Transfer 4<br>T1105 |
| Virtualization/Sandbox Eva... 2<br>T1497 | | System Information Disco... 4<br>T1082 | Video Capture 1<br>T1125 | Non-Standard Port 1<br>T1571 |

## General Information

| | |
|---|---|
| Sample Name: | I8tdYrt7zF.exe |
| Analysis ID: | 602426 |
| MD5: | 22f55d6bdde23b66f2db7d... |
| SHA1: | 88578556b91393a06e68a... |
| SHA256: | c3095cea4f4901ea9a22e6... |
| Tags: | CobaltStrike exe |

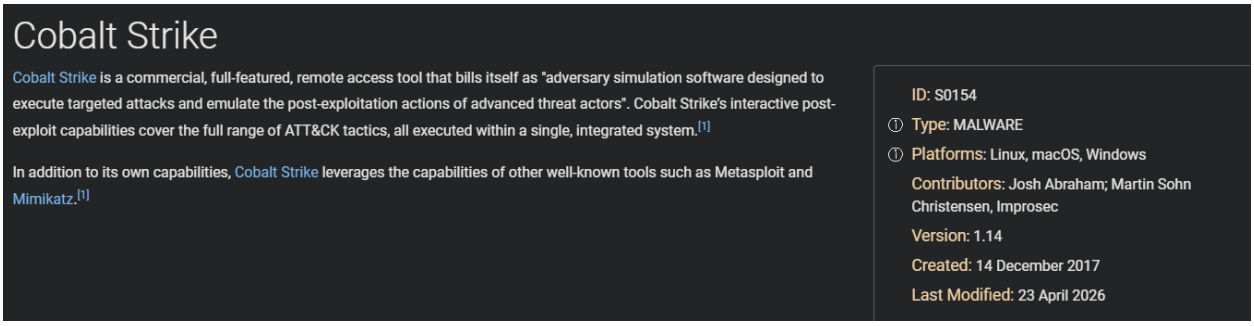
## Process Tree

- System is w10x64
- I8tdYrt7zF.exe (PID: 3420 cmdline: "C:\Users\user\Desktop\I8tdYrt7zF.exe" MD5: 22F55D6BDDE23B66F2DB7DB134D9519E)
  - windowsUpdate.exe (PID: 6932 cmdline: "C:\Windows\System32\windowsUpdate.exe" MD5: 05D764F508231105BB212107C782DB80)
  - windowsUpdate.exe (PID: 7092 cmdline: "C:\Windows\System\windowsUpdate.exe" MD5: 05D764F508231105BB212107C782DB80)
  - windowsUpdate.exe (PID: 384 cmdline: "C:\Windows\System32\windowsUpdate.exe" MD5: 05D764F508231105BB212107C782DB80)
  - windowsUpdate.exe (PID: 6688 cmdline: "C:\Windows\System\windowsUpdate.exe" MD5: 05D764F508231105BB212107C782DB80)
- cleanup



**Malicious Software:** Cobalt Strike

Cobalt Strike is a known adversary simulation software identified by Mitre ATT&CK as S0154. It is normally used by organizations to test the security of their infrastructure, but it is often leveraged by threat actors to allow compromised hosts to beacon out to their C2 server and complete post-exploitation actions.




# Recommendations

- Investigate the activity on the host around 2022-04-04 02:48:19 UTC to verify malicious behavior, note technique that may affect the organization, and discover how this malware was introduced to our environment
- Query the network for the malicious file hashes and traffic with the malicious IP address and domains to determine other affected devices.
- Isolate all affected devices from the network to limit further damage.
- Hunt for techniques used in the environment related to Cobalt Strike